



## USE ALEXA TO KEEP TRACK OF WHAT YOU EAT

If you are one of those calorie-conscious types, then you can actually ask Alexa to estimate the amount of calories in the foodstuff that you eat. Simply ask,



Using Alexa to count calories

Alexa, how many calories does so-and-so dish have, and Alexa will give an answer. We tested out the feature on a whole bunch of Indian foodstuff, and Alexa was surprisingly able to give an answer to most of the queries.



## SET UP YOUR VOICE PROFILE

Voice profiles are how Alexa recognises individuals in the household, and are useful for personalised services and skills. Go to Settings > Profile > Voice Profile on the app to set up your voice profile, which involves repeating four phrases when prompted by Alexa. Note that the procedure is much faster on an Echo device than the Smartphone app, but the profile setup either way works on all connected devices, as long as they are signed in using the same Amazon account. To check

if Alexa has got it right, just say Alexa, who am I? If Alexa still does not recognise you, you can just say "Alexa, learn my voice" to repeat the process. Usually repeating the voice profile setup is not necessary, and Alexa suddenly seems to remember who is speaking from then on.



## FOLLOW-UP MODE

If you are regularly communicating with your Echo, it can be irritating to say Alexa every time you ask a question. You can set up the device so that you can chain multiple tasks together, or ask follow up questions and Alexa understands that you are addressing her. Go to Settings > Device Settings > Your Device > Follow-Up Mode and toggle the switch.



## VOICE RESPONSES

There are a couple of options that lets you change how Alexa responds to your questions. The first is the Brief Mode, where Alexa responds with a beep to indicate that she is active, instead of a one of the pre-set phrases to requests. It also makes Alexa's responses snappier and quicker. However, leaving it turned off is a more natural way to interact with the assistant. Then, there is the Whisper Mode, which is great to use during the night, or around sleeping kids. When turned on, Alexa responds to your questions in a low whisper, as long as you whisper the questions yourself. You do not need to turn Whisper Mode on and off regularly, doing it once is enough. Just say Alexa, turn on Whisper Mode, or Alexa turn on Brief Mode to activate these options, both of them are

## ALEXA EASTER EGGS

Try telling Alexa these for some funny responses

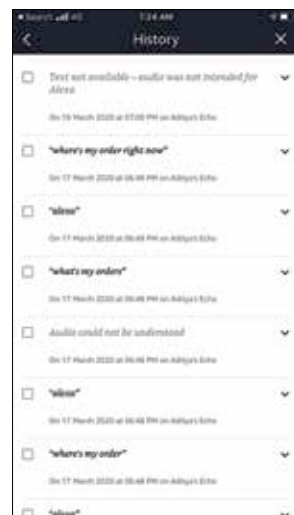
- Alexa, I am your father
- Alexa, is the cake a lie?
- Alexa, where is my father?
- Alexa, do a barrel roll!
- Alexa, can you get me a job?
- Alexa, winter is coming.

turned off by default. The toggles for these options are available in Settings > Voice Responses.



## DELETE YOUR HISTORY

Alexa keeps a history of all recorded interactions. This includes not just the information requested, but an actual audio clip of the sounds at that time. If you are concerned about privacy, you can go to Settings > Device Settings > History which opens up a web page with all your recordings. You



Deleting the audio files from your history

can select a date range for review, and begin deleting whatever you do not want saved, or everything at once. It is also possible to listen to the clips, which will inform you of all the

times Alexa thought she was being spoken to, even though she was not. In fact, Alexa even tags these clips as "audio was not meant for Alexa", then goes ahead and keeps them. All these clips are important because it allows Alexa to better understand and respond as you use

the device more. However, you can choose to delete any of these clips if you are willing to degrade the quality of the responses. There is also a setting here that allows you to delete the history using a voice command, just switch the toggle to On. You can also choose to filter the requests based on the device that the command was issued to.



## CREATE CUSTOM RESPONSES

One of the most fun things to do with Alexa is to set up custom responses. Just head over to blueprints.amazon.in and sign in using the Amazon account linked with your Alexa device. Under the Featured Blueprints section, click on Custom Q&A then Make Your Own. Now, simply type in a question and the answer that you want. You can set up as many custom responses that you want, and this will replace any programming that Alexa already has for those particular questions. Do note that the question has to be asked clearly for Alexa to understand, so do not use complicated words for the custom responses. For more tips, details on how to use blueprints, IFTTT integration, and even making your own custom skills are available in the Feb 2020 issue of Digit.